

COFFEE BAR

DELHI



Latte at leisure

It's the urbanite's new hang-out zone, a place to think, talk, be and occasionally even to drink coffee

■ By Chitra Subramanyam

An urban village chaupal, an extension of the college canteen or a haven from the hustle bustle of modern life, call it what you will. This is the café, where the strong aroma of coffee mingles with the chatter of people; the clackety-clack of fingers on keyboards or the occasional whoops of victory as yet another chess game comes to an end. This is the place where regulars, writers, morning walkers or friends converge to do their own thing—read a book, search for their muse or wrap up pending work. The reasons are different and not everyone is a coffee aficionado. In fact, it's not about the coffee. A documentary and advertising filmmaker, Shailendra Uniyal, 32, a regular at the IT Barista in Delhi goes to the café to take a break. "I often come here to think," he says.

Or in some cases to do. At

the café, a mother gets up, leaving her son sitting with a girl. The couple, who it seems have just been introduced, start talking. Their voices are soft, almost drowned out by the chatter around them. A man approaches the counter, smiling at the server. No words are exchanged; the server nods a greeting and taps out the order. One always knows what a regular needs. A latte with an extra shot. Another regular walks in. The tables usually outside the store have been removed and he's miffed. An argument follows and he walks out, but first he orders his coffee. He sits outside and sips his drink. Nothing can compel him to shift base. This is his café.

A sentiment 41-year-old Ajoy Bhan, who works in advertising, echoes. "This is my *garambhoomi*, an intrinsic part of my life," he says. Bhan lives in Gurgaon, Haryana, but only visits this particular café

YOUR MOVE: 6 p.m. and a chess game's underway

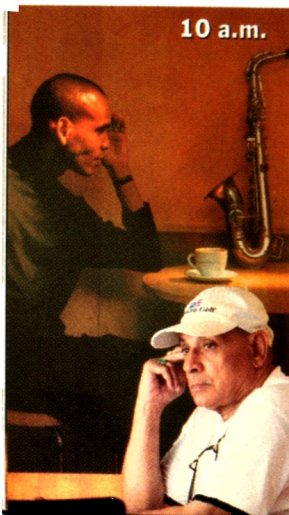
and has been doing so for over four years. Twelve hours later, the next day, the café is still brimming. This time with morning walkers. They trickle in for their morning coffee, wiping sweat off their brows. As noon rolls around, a couple walks in and chooses the farthest corner of the room. Heads together, arms linked like Siamese twins, the two remain oblivious to the people around them.

This is new India's new hang-out. A place that offers people a chance to just be themselves. This is a place that offers security, anonymity, a ground to meet people or just be with oneself, reading the latest Harry Potter, or catching up with the newspaper. Where strangers can become friends and sometimes friends can fall out. This is life, measured in more than just coffee spoons.



7 THE NUMBER OF COFFEE BEANS BABA BUDAN SMUGGLED OUT OF YEMEN INTO INDIA WHILE ON A PILGRIMAGE TO MECCA. HE HID THEM AROUND HIS BELLY.

10 a.m.



NOON



8 p.m.

